

## A RETROSPECTIVE ON ITERATED EXPECTATION

By HANSON CHAR

*Revised 24 May 2026*

In general, thanks to iterated expectation—also known as Adam’s Law—the **unconditional expectation of a conditional expectation** is simply the **unconditional expectation**:

$$\mathbf{E}[\mathbf{E}[X \mid U, V, \dots]] = \mathbf{E}[X].$$

The **conditional expectation of a conditional expectation behaves like a filter**: whenever the outer conditioning set is a subset of the inner, the result collapses to the outer conditional expectation. For example,

$$\mathbf{E}\left[\mathbf{E}[X \mid U, V, Y, Z] \mid V, Z\right] = \mathbf{E}[X \mid V, Z].$$

If the **conditioning set contains the random variable** itself, the expectation **collapses** to that variable. For example,

$$\mathbf{E}[X \mid W, X, Y] = X.$$

Trivially, any **expectation**—conditional or unconditional—of an **unconditional expectation** is just **the unconditional expectation**, simply because  $\mathbf{E}[X]$  is a constant and therefore independent of any conditioning information:

$$\mathbf{E}\left[\mathbf{E}[X] \mid X, Y, Z\right] = \mathbf{E}[X].$$

It is also worth pointing out the immense power of iterated expectation—it provides a shortcut to complicated problems, bypassing integration entirely, and is especially valuable when no closed form is available.

Happy iterating expectations!

—